

# Korea Daily Brief

Monday, September 28, 2026

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**RE:** Seoul summons Ukrainian envoy over NK POW disclosure · DMZ landmine probe advances · KOSPI drops 2.7% on chip selloff · Russian envoy presents credentials in Pyongyang

KOSPI  
**6,889.74**  
▼ -2.7%

USD/KRW  
**1,359.88**  
▼ -0.6%

BRENT  
**\$101.07**  
▼ -3.1%

BOK RATE  
**2.50%**  
Sep 2026

## • TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Seoul summoned Ukraine's chargé d'affaires and demanded a formal apology after President Zelenskyy unilaterally disclosed at the UN General Assembly that two North Korean POWs had been transferred to South Korea, which Seoul says violated a bilateral non-disclosure agreement.
- 2 The ROK-UNC joint investigation team entered the DMZ blast site as witness statements point to an undetonated wooden-box landmine; Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul vowed 'corresponding measures' if the mine is confirmed as North Korean in origin.
- 3 KOSPI fell 2.7% to 6,889.74 on chip-sector profit-taking, with Samsung Electronics leading losses, while South Korea's three-year bond yield rose to its highest level since 2022.

## • TOP STORIES

### US-KOREA

#### Seoul summons Ukrainian envoy, demands apology over unilateral NK POW disclosure

South Korea's Foreign Ministry called in Ukrainian chargé d'affaires **Andrii Vieshin** on Monday after President Zelenskyy publicly disclosed at the UN General Assembly that two North Korean prisoners of war had been transferred to South Korea — a fact Seoul says was covered by a bilateral non-disclosure agreement. First Vice FM **Park Yoon-ju** demanded a formal apology and non-recurrence; Ukraine's presidential office had denied any such agreement existed. Seoul held the POWs after they were captured fighting for Russian forces in Ukraine and transferred under a confidential arrangement; the disclosure now intersects with Seoul's broader effort to avoid direct diplomatic exposure over North Korean troop deployments.

Yonhap, Bloomberg, Reuters, CNN, Washington Post, AP, Financial Times — Sep 28

### DPRK

#### Witness statements point to wooden-box landmine at DMZ blast site; defense minister vows response

Soldiers' accounts from the September 21 DMZ explosion that injured three ROK troops describe an undetonated wooden-box landmine spotted at the blast site — a design consistent with North Korean-origin mines. ROK military and UN Command completed a first joint on-site investigation Sunday and plan further probes; Defense Minister **Kang Shin-chul** vowed 'appropriate corresponding measures' if the mine is confirmed as North Korean. Wooden-box mines are a known DPRK mine type deployed along the DMZ and were implicated in a 2015 blast that maimed two ROK soldiers near Paju.

Yonhap, Reuters — Sep 28

#### NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

### Russia's new ambassador presents credentials in Pyongyang, formally begins posting

**Andrei Podelyshev**, Russia's newly arrived ambassador to North Korea, presented credentials to **Kim Myong Jin**, head of the DPRK Foreign Ministry's Second Protocol Department, on Monday — marking the formal start of his posting after arriving Saturday. Podelyshev replaces the previous envoy; his arrival was reported by NK News on September 26. The formal credentialing comes as the Tumangang-Khasan road bridge opened September 8 and the Sinuiju-Dandong crossing approaches completion, deepening the bilateral infrastructure underpinning the cooperation axis.

NK News — Sep 28

#### • OVERNIGHT

|                 |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DPRK            | Record 39% of South Koreans say reunification with North is impossible: SNU annual poll · NK News<br>Highest share since survey launched in 2007, up 3.5pp.                            |
| DPRK            | The Economist: Will Trump get to meet Kim Jong Un again? · The Economist<br>Pyongyang conditioning any meeting on US dropping disarmament demands.                                     |
| NK-RUSSIA-CHINA | Vietnam unveils plaque honoring DPRK soldiers who fought in Vietnam War; memorial sculptures to follow · NK News<br>Vice Defense Minister Ryo Chol Ung attended Hanoi ceremony Friday. |
| BUSINESS        | South Korea's three-year bond yield rises to highest level since 2022 · Bloomberg<br>Yield spike coincides with KOSPI drop and chip-sector selloff.                                    |
| BUSINESS        | Hanwha Ocean wins 680 billion-won order to build two LNG carriers · Yonhap English<br>Order announced Monday; sector amid broader shipbuilding expansion push.                         |
| BUSINESS        | CPTPP membership projected to grow ROK GDP by 0.38% over 10 years: government study · Yonhap English<br>Government projection released Monday ahead of formal accession discussions.   |

#### • STAT OF THE DAY

# 39%

South Koreans who say reunification is impossible

Seoul National University's Institute for Peace and Unification Studies annual poll released today recorded the highest share of respondents calling reunification impossible since the survey began in 2007, up 3.5 percentage points from the previous year.

NK News, citing SNU Institute for Peace and Unification Studies poll

## PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

### Complete KCNA silence today

KIM JONG UN

- No appearance (6d since last)

SENIOR OFFICIALS

**Ryo Chol-ung · Vice Minister of National Defense**

Attended the Vietnam Military History Museum ceremony in Hanoi on Friday for the unveiling of a plaque honoring DPRK soldiers who fought in the Vietnam War.

**Bottom line:** KCNA produced no Korea-relevant output today; Kim Jong Un last confirmed publicly September 22 — now six days ago. Watch for Punggye-ri seismic activity and Kim's next public appearance.

## ● ROK GOVERNMENT

President + Ministries · Monday, September 28, 2026

외교부 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

### Ukraine chargé d'affaires summoned over NK POW disclosure

First Vice FM Park Yoon-ju

First Vice Foreign Minister **Park Yoon-ju** called in Ukrainian chargé d'affaires Andrii Vieshin on Monday afternoon, conveying Seoul's 'strong regret' and demanding an official apology and non-recurrence after Ukraine unilaterally disclosed the transfer of two North Korean POW soldiers to South Korea at the UNGA. Seoul asserts a bilateral non-disclosure agreement was in place; Ukraine's presidential office had issued a statement denying any such agreement existed.

[Primary](#) [뉴스](#) [↗](#)

국방부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

### Defense minister pledges 'corresponding measures' if DMZ blast confirmed as NK mine

Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul

**Kang Shin-chul** stated that 'appropriate corresponding measures' would follow if investigation confirms the DMZ explosion that injured three soldiers on September 21 was caused by a North Korean wooden-box landmine. ROK military and UN Command conducted a joint on-site investigation on Sunday and planned further probes; witness statements describe an undetonated wooden-box landmine spotted at the blast site.

[Primary](#) [Yonhap EN](#) [↗](#)

통일부 · MINISTRY OF UNIFICATION

## Unification minister to visit Ireland, Northern Ireland, and Germany this week

Unification Minister Chung Dong-young

**Chung Dong-young** departs this week for visits to Ireland, Northern Ireland, and Germany, in a diplomatic outreach mission the ministry framed around inter-Korean engagement models and dialogue with relevant European governments.

[Primary](#) [Yonhap EN](#) ↗

### PERSONNEL CHANGES

#### Jeong Woo-sik **APPOINTED**

Director, Korea Atomic Energy Research Institute

Jeong Woo-sik was selected as the new head of the Korea Atomic Energy Research Institute, per [조선일보](#) reporting Monday. Kang Sang-hee was separately appointed to head the Korea Electrotechnology Research Institute.

#### Kang Sang-hee **APPOINTED**

Director, Korea Electrotechnology Research Institute

Kang Sang-hee was appointed director of the Korea Electrotechnology Research Institute, announced Monday alongside the KAERI appointment.

### NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

#### Dispute over calling Samsung and SK chiefs as witnesses for Honam semiconductor megaproject audit

Climate, Energy, Environment and Labor Committee (기후노동위)

The PPP demanded Samsung Electronics Chairman Lee Jae-yong and SK Group Chairman Choi Tae-won appear as witnesses at the National Assembly audit to explain their investment decisions on the Honam semiconductor cluster, alleging government pressure. The Democratic Party opposed their appearance; only Sampo Group Chairman Jeong Do-won and one other participant were initially adopted as witnesses, with further negotiations ordered.

### • US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

Steel and aluminium remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge (10%) expired July 24, leaving no single baseline reciprocal tariff. Section 301, launched March 11, 2026 against 16 partners including South Korea, is now the primary vehicle for any new tariff action.

### TARIFFS

## EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now the primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

**WATCH THIS DATE**

next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

**SECTOR RATES**

|                                                      |                                  |           |
|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------|
| Steel & Aluminum                                     | SECTION 232                      | 50%       |
| Copper                                               | SECTION 232                      | 50%       |
| Automobiles & Auto Parts                             | SECTION 232                      | 15%       |
| Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives                   | SECTION 232                      | 15%       |
| Semiconductors (advanced logic)                      | SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002) | 25%       |
| Pharmaceuticals                                      | SECTION 232                      | up to 15% |
| Civil Aircraft & Parts                               | US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION          | 0%        |
| Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources | ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST            | 0%        |

**FULL TRADE REFERENCE →**

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

**• BUSINESS & ECONOMY****FINANCE · YONHAP ENGLISH****KOSPI sinks over 2.5% on chip-sector profit-taking**

South Korean shares fell *more than 2.5%* Monday on broad chip-sector profit-taking, with Samsung Electronics leading losses. The KOSPI closed at 6,889.74, down 2.7%, the sharpest single-day drop in weeks, coinciding with a rise in the three-year bond yield to its highest level since 2022.

Samsung Electronics

**TECH · 매일경제****Samsung Electro-Mechanics to invest 6.78 trillion won in AI server substrate capacity**

Samsung Electro-Mechanics disclosed Monday it will invest *6.78 trillion won* in domestic and overseas production facilities for AI server semiconductor substrates, targeting Sejong plant expansion as the primary site. The announcement comes as AI infrastructure demand accelerates and the company positions substrates as a core product alongside HBM.

Samsung Electro-Mechanics

**MANUFACTURING · YONHAP ENGLISH****LG Chem and Volkswagen agree to jointly develop sustainable mobility materials**

LG Chem and Volkswagen announced a joint development agreement for sustainable mobility materials, extending LG Chem's European automotive partnership as EV material supply chains undergo reconfiguration under IRA sourcing constraints.

## • NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

[RUSSIA-KOREA](#) · [RUSSIA-DIPLOMATIC](#) · [EAI](#)

### EAI: South Korea-Ukraine diplomatic conflict over NK POW repatriation disclosure and analysis of NK-Russia military cooperation

EAI's analysis examines the diplomatic fallout from Ukraine's unilateral POW disclosure alongside the structural underpinnings of North Korea-Russia military cooperation, framing the bilateral spat as a symptom of deeper tensions over the disposition of DPRK troops deployed to assist Russia. The analysis connects Seoul's sensitivity to the POW issue with its need to avoid direct confrontation with Pyongyang over what Pyongyang frames as a legitimate bilateral military arrangement with Moscow.

[TRILATERAL](#) · [EAI](#)

### EAI releases 2025 trilateral Korea-Japan-US joint public opinion poll results

The East Asia Institute released results of the 2025 EAI-API-KEI first trilateral Korea-Japan-US joint public opinion survey alongside the 12th Korea-Japan joint poll, providing the latest baseline data on public attitudes toward alliance cooperation and bilateral relations in all three countries.

[CHINA-KOREA](#) · [CHINA-TRADE](#) · [NK PRO](#)

### Chinese customs in Dandong seize truck smuggling 15 categories of goods into North Korea

Dandong customs authorities intercepted a freight truck smuggling goods into North Korea earlier this year, seizing machines including dehumidifiers, frying pans, shoes, supplements, and cosmetics hidden behind declared cargo, while allowing household goods to pass. The partial interdiction illustrates the selective enforcement pattern along the Sinuiju–Dandong corridor as the new Yalu River bridge nears completion.

## • PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

**37.9%**

▼ 1 pts vs 2026-09-11

Realmeter / Gallup Korea · September 28, 2026

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 37% across 4 readings

RULING  
Democratic

**39%**

OPPOSITION  
People Power

**25%**

INDEPENDENTS

**26%**

**Gallup Korea Spotlight** September 28, 2026

**Presidential approval rebound:** President Lee Jae-myung's approval rose for the second consecutive week to 37.9%, per a poll reported Monday by Yonhap, recovering from the 37% low recorded September 18.

## • UPCOMING

Oct  
1

### **ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)**

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct  
3

### **National Foundation Day (개천절)**

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct  
9

### **Hangul Day (한글날)**

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct  
10

### **Workers' Party founding day**

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

## • THE WIRE

### DPRK

REUTERS

#### **Reuters: What comes next for North Korean soldiers transferred from Ukraine to South Korea?**

Reuters examines legal status, intelligence value, and resettlement prospects for the two DPRK POWs now in South Korea. The transfer is the first confirmed return of DPRK soldiers who fought in Ukraine.

### BUSINESS

YONHAP ENGLISH

#### **KAI and POSCO International team up for aerospace cooperation in Mexico**

Korea Aerospace Industries and POSCO International announced an aerospace cooperation partnership targeting the Mexican market, aligning with President Lee's supply chain and tech diplomacy push during his recent Mexico visit.

### TECHNOLOGY

YONHAP ENGLISH

#### **South Korea's AI adoption rate exceeds 40%, ranks 12th globally: report**

South Korea's AI adoption rate surpassed 40% and ranked 12th globally, according to a report released Monday. The figure underpins the Lee administration's 'AI for All' (모두의 AI) policy framework highlighted by the MSIT minister.

## • ANALYSIS

### OFFICIALS ON X

**President Lee Jae-myung** @Jaemyung\_Lee

“This is a measure that should obviously be taken, albeit belatedly. It is a policy that the whole world, including China, is implementing.”

**Context:** Post appears in context of a trade or economic policy action; Lee's framing as 'overdue but necessary' and reference to China's own adoption suggests the post relates to a regulatory or industrial policy measure with China-trade dimensions, consistent with his concurrent posts on ROK export trends and China economic relations.

[View on X](#) →

#### US Ambassador to ROK @USAmbROK

“Had a productive meeting with KFTC Chairperson Ju Biung-ghi to discuss the investment climate in Korea and to highlight the positive role that US companies play in the innovative Korean economy.”

**Context:** Meeting with the Korea Fair Trade Commission chair touches on the investment environment for US firms operating in South Korea, a standing concern amid ROK regulatory scrutiny of major technology platforms.

[View on X](#) →

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



**Kang Shin-chul**  
ROK Defense Minister

*“Appropriate corresponding measures will be taken if the DMZ blast is confirmed to have been caused by North Korean mines.”*

**Analyst:** Statement follows the ROK-UNC joint on-site investigation Sunday; a second investigation is planned as witness accounts describe a wooden-box landmine at the Sep 21 blast site that injured three ROK soldiers.

[Source](#) →



**Park Yoon-ju**  
ROK First Vice Foreign Minister

*“Ukraine's presidential office issuing false information that no non-disclosure agreement existed seriously damages trust between the two governments and harms the bilateral relationship.”*

**Analyst:** Park conveyed Seoul's position directly to Ukrainian chargé d'affaires Andrii Vieshin on Monday; Seoul's statement describes a 'clear bilateral agreement' on non-disclosure that Ukraine denied.

[Source](#) →

## COMMENTARY

EAI

### Kim Jong Un's Inspection of Weapons Factories and Instructions to Strengthen AI and Automated Production Capabilities: Security Implications for the Korean Peninsula and Policy Directions

EAI analyzes Kim Jong Un's September 19 inspection tour of munitions factories under the Second Economic Commission, during which he called for AI integration and automation of weapons systems. The piece maps security implications for the peninsula and proposes policy directions for Seoul and Washington in response to a DPRK defense-industrial modernization drive.

EAI

### North Korea's Warning of 'Collective Punishment' and the Debate over South Korea's Integration into the US-ROK Collective Defense System: Situation Analysis and Countermeasures

EAI situational analysis addresses KCNA's explicit September 26 'collective punishment' threat in the context of the ROK-US collective defense debate, assessing escalation risk and recommending countermeasures. The piece connects the threat to the ongoing THAAD/extended deterrence architecture debate and DPRK's nuclear irreversibility declarations of the same week.

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

NK NEWS / 헤럴드경제 · SEP 25-26 — DUAL-COAST WARSHIP CONSTRUCTION CONFIRMED

## North Korea building new warships simultaneously on east and west coasts

NK News satellite imagery analysis confirms new warship construction has begun at Chongjin Shipyard on the east coast and Nampho Shipyard on the west coast since early July 2026 — dual-coast concurrent construction activity. The imagery corroborates the Sinpo South Shipyard tracker's elevated status and extends the pattern of post-Kang Kon commissioning naval expansion noted since the Sep 8 destroyer ceremony. No new imagery was reported today for other monitored DPRK facilities.

→ Sinpo South Shipyard

헤럴드경제 ↗ · Korea Times ↗

### ELEVATED ▲

#### Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.

imagery as of 2026-09-10

### ACTIVITY ▲

#### Sinpo South Shipyard

NK News satellite imagery (Sep 25-26) confirms new warship construction begun at Chongjin Shipyard (east coast) and Nampho Shipyard (west coast) since early July — dual-coast concurrent construction. Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine exited drydock after 2+ years of fitting-out but still not operational as of May 2025. New submarine construction begun in separate bay.

imagery as of 2026-09-26

### ACTIVITY ▲

#### Punggye-ri Nuclear Test Site

Nov 2025: ROK DIA assessed Tunnel No. 3 is test-ready and a nuclear test can be conducted at any time upon political decision. Site maintained at high readiness since mid-2024. The Sep 9, 2016 fifth nuclear test 10-year anniversary fell earlier this month; post-anniversary period historically carries elevated test risk. CNN/Yonhap reported Sep 18 that nearly 1,400 seismic events have been detected near the site since the 2017 test.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

### ALERT ▲

#### Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind. NK News reporting confirms North Korea remains closed to private car travel via the bridge; crossings are limited to organized bus tours per the Association of Tour Operators of Russia (ATOR). NBC News analysis (Sep 15) frames the bridge alongside the

near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong crossing as dual infrastructure bets by Pyongyang.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

**ACTIVITY ▲**

**Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border)**

Sep 21, 2026: ROK Embassy in Beijing confirmed the cargo carried by heavy trucks crossing the new Yalu River bridge on Sep 17 consisted of air-conditioning units (HVAC equipment) destined for the customs building, indicating construction is roughly 70-80% complete. Embassy source said the bridge could open approximately one month after building completion following a trial period, with the NK-China diplomatic anniversary (Oct 6) cited as a possible opening date. DPRK national insignia already installed on the North Korean customs building.

imagery as of 2026-09-21

**ACTIVITY ▲**

**Rason SEZ**

Sep 21-22, 2026: NK Pro satellite imagery analysis shows a likely Russian cargo vessel docked at Rason for the first time since May 2026 — a roughly four-month gap after near-continuous activity in 2024-2025. Nov 2025: Chinese businesspeople re-entry to Rason SEZ expanded. Coal exports through Rason at highest levels in years throughout 2025. Arms export berth also active.

imagery as of 2026-09-22

**ACTIVITY ▲**

**Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)**

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail. NK News satellite imagery (Sep 18) shows ongoing upgrades to DPRK urban warfare training facilities consistent with troops rotating back from Russia.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

4 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-09.

**CSIS**

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KOREA  
CHAIR

Washington, D.C.

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